# *Guru* Cool

Spirituality goes trendy as its **practitioners take to social media to reach out to angst-ridden Gen Z**. But do they succeed in teaching them anything deeper than the latest mumbo-jumbo?

**By Sonali Acharjee**



*Photograph by* HARDIK CHHABRA, *Location courtesy* PLUM BY BENT CHAIR

They call her the Meerabai of Gen Z. Twenty-seven-year-old Jaya Kishori from Kolkata turns Krishna folktales into 30-second clips to address issues of loneliness, friendship and lack of self-confidence. This has helped 'Jaya didi', as she is known, gain over 1.9 million followers on Facebook and another two million on YouTube. Her namesake, Jaya Pandey, a 16-year-old in Delhi, swears by her. "I have to keep shifting schools because my par-ents are in the army," says Pandey. "But wherever I go, Jaya didi is with me. I would be lost in the maze of change without her as my guide."

There is also Devi Ushma Kishoriji from Jhansi. Infinitely wise for a 14-year-old, she gets regular leave from school to post new content for her 10,000 follow-ers on Instagram. Most of her posts are about finding peace amidst the bewildering experiences of life.

Meet the new spirituality influencers. So successful have they become that the Advertising Standards Council of India have named them as a separate catego-ry in their 2023 report 'Wielding influence, nurturing trust'. For a generation troubled by self-doubt, anxiety and extreme insecurity, they offer a spiritual salve, in a